



SQL**SENSEI**

SQL Practice Resource Guide

The complete, ranked list of where to actually practice SQL — from beginner to FAANG-ready. No fluff, just the platforms that work.

15+

Practice platforms

8

Categories

100%

Verified resources

1

Honest roadmap

v1.0 • Curated for SQLSENSEI students github.com/Mani5266/sql

01 The Honest Roadmap

Don't grind every site. Follow this exact sequence and you'll be interview-ready in 4-6 weeks.

The path that actually works

1 Finish SQLSENSEI Levels 1-3 first

Get the fundamentals locked in (SELECT, JOIN, GROUP BY, subqueries). Don't skip the exercises.

2 Grind LeetCode SQL Easy → Medium (~50 problems)

This builds the muscle memory. Aim for 2-3 problems/day for 3-4 weeks.

3 Switch to DataLemur / StrataScratch for company-tagged questions

Filter by your target company for the last 2-3 weeks before interviews. Real questions, real format.

4 Do the 8 Week SQL Challenge (optional but powerful)

If you want to feel what real analytics work looks like. Builds confidence and portfolio.

5 Mock interview on Pramp before the real thing

Free peer-to-peer mock interviews. Talking through SQL out loud is a separate skill.

02 Tier 1 — Start Here

These three sites cover 80% of what you need. If you only use these three, you'll be fine.

LeetCode SQL

leetcode.com/problemset/database/

FREEMIUM

★ BEST OVERALL

EASY → HARD

FAANG

250+ SQL problems tagged by difficulty. The de facto standard for SQL interview prep. Discussion forums for every problem.

Why: Every FAANG interviewer has seen these problems. Solving the Top 50 SQL list essentially guarantees you've seen the pattern before in your interview.

DataLemur

datalemur.com

FREEMIUM

★ BEST FOR FAANG DS

META • AMAZON • NETFLIX

Made by an ex-Meta data scientist. Real interview questions from Meta, Amazon, Netflix, etc. Clean UI, focused purely on SQL for data roles.

Why: The free questions are higher quality than most paid platforms. Specifically targets data science / analytics SQL rounds.

StrataScratch

stratascratch.com

FREEMIUM

★ MOST COMPANIES

50+ COMPANIES

Real questions from 50+ companies with company tags, difficulty filters, and detailed solutions. Strong free tier.

Why: Widest variety of company-specific questions. If you're targeting a less common company (Uber, Airbnb, Stripe), this beats LeetCode.

03 For Fundamentals (Beginners)

If you're still learning basics — use these alongside SQLSENSEI Levels 1-2.

SQLZoo

sqlzoo.net

FREE

BEGINNER

Interactive lessons, no signup. Goes from SELECT to window functions step by step.

When: Perfect right after SQLSENSEI Level 1-2 to reinforce basics with different practice problems.

Mode SQL Tutorial

mode.com/sql-tutorial/

FREE

BEGINNER → INTERMEDIATE

Well-written tutorials using realistic startup datasets. Best free SQL course on the internet for quality of writing.

Why: Teaches SQL the way analysts actually use it, not the way textbooks do.

SQLBolt

sqlbolt.com

FREE

ABSOLUTE BEGINNER

Bite-size interactive lessons, very gentle. Great if you're completely new and SQLZoo feels too fast.

When: Day 1-3 of your SQL journey. Read a chapter, do the exercises, done.

W3Schools SQL Tutorial

w3schools.com/sql/

FREE

REFERENCE

Syntax reference with "Try it yourself" sandboxes. Not a course, but a useful lookup for syntax.

When: Use it like a dictionary, not a learning path.

04 For Pattern Grinding

Once you've done basics — drill patterns until they're muscle memory.

HackerRank SQL

hackerrank.com/domains/sql

FREE

EASY → HARD

Tracks for Basic Select, Advanced Select, Aggregations, Basic Join, Advanced Join. Less interview-y than LeetCode but more structured.

When: *If LeetCode feels overwhelming, HackerRank's tracks are friendlier organization.*

Codewars SQL

codewars.com/?language=sql

FREE

VARIED

Community-submitted SQL "katas" ranked by difficulty (kyu/dan). Strong on creative problems you won't see elsewhere.

When: *When you want unusual problems to push out of your comfort zone.*

PgExercises

pgexercises.com

FREE

INTERMEDIATE

POSTGRESQL FOCUS

PostgreSQL-specific exercises on a country club booking dataset. Covers joins, dates, recursion, aggregations.

When: *If you're targeting a Postgres-heavy job (most startups).*

05 Real-World / Messy Data

Practice on actual business datasets, not toy problems.

8 Week SQL Challenge

8weeksqlchallenge.com

FREE

★ BEST FOR PORTFOLIO

INTERMEDIATE → HARD

8 case studies on real business datasets (Pizza Runner, Danny's Diner, Data Mart, etc). Each one is a mini analytics project.

Why: *The closest you can get to real analyst work without a job. Great GitHub portfolio material.*

Kaggle SQL Scavenger Hunt

kaggle.com/learn/intro-to-sql

FREE

BIGQUERY

Practice on Kaggle's free BigQuery datasets — Stack Overflow, Hacker News, Reddit, GitHub commits. Real data, real scale.

Why: *Practice on tables with millions of rows. Forces you to think about efficiency.*

Advent of SQL

adventofsql.com

FREE

ESCALATING

Yearly puzzle event in December. One SQL puzzle per day for 25 days, getting progressively harder.

When: *December — great way to keep your skills sharp with a community.*

Select Star SQL

selectstarsql.com

FREE

INTERMEDIATE

Free interactive book using death-row inmate data (Texas execution records). Unconventional but memorable.

When: *If you learn better through storytelling than abstract problems.*

06 Interview-Specific Platforms

Mock interviews, live coding, and structured prep paths.

InterviewQuery

interviewquery.com

FREEMIUM

DATA SCIENCE FOCUSED

SQL + Python + statistics + product sense for data science interviews. Strong company-tagged question bank.

When: *If you're targeting data science / analytics roles specifically (not data engineering).*

Pramp

pramp.com

FREE

★ MOCK INTERVIEWS

Free peer-to-peer mock interviews. Live video, shared code editor, you alternate being interviewer and interviewee.

Why: *Coding SQL alone is 10x easier than coding it while someone watches and asks follow-ups. This bridges the gap.*

Exercism SQL Track

exercism.org/tracks/sqlite

FREE

VARIED

SQLite track with a mentor system — real humans review your solutions and suggest improvements.

Why: *Free human feedback on your queries is rare and valuable.*

07 Quick Comparison

If you're going to pick just one for this week, here's the matrix.

PLATFORM	BEST FOR	COST	DIFFICULTY	COMPANY TAGS
LeetCode	Interview prep, FAANG	Freemium	Easy → Hard	✓ Premium
DataLemur	FAANG data science	Freemium	Easy → Hard	✓ Free
StrataScratch	Most companies covered	Freemium	Easy → Hard	✓ Free
HackerRank	Structured tracks	Free	Easy → Hard	—
SQLZoo	Beginner fundamentals	Free	Easy → Medium	—
Mode Tutorial	Quality teaching	Free	Easy → Medium	—
SQLBolt	Day 1 of SQL	Free	Easy	—
8 Week SQL	Real-world projects	Free	Medium → Hard	—
Kaggle	Big data, BigQuery	Free	Medium	—
PgExercises	PostgreSQL deep dive	Free	Medium → Hard	—
Codewars	Creative puzzles	Free	Varied	—
Advent of SQL	December grind	Free	Easy → Hard	—
InterviewQuery	DS interviews	Freemium	Medium → Hard	✓
Pramp	Mock interviews	Free	Real format	—
Exercism	Human feedback	Free	Easy → Hard	—

The Honest Recommendation

Skip 90% of these. More platforms ≠ more skill. Here's exactly what to do:

Week 1-2: Finish SQLSENSEI Levels 1-3.

Week 3-5: LeetCode SQL — 50 Easy + 30 Medium problems. That's it.

Week 6 (pre-interview): DataLemur, filter by your target company. Do 15-20 questions.

Week 7+: Pramp for 2-3 mock interviews. Talk through your SQL out loud.

Don't: Bounce between platforms thinking variety = mastery. Pick one, finish it, then move on.

08 Pro Tips for Practice

⚡ THE 80/20 OF SQL

- JOINS — in 90% of questions
- GROUP BY + aggregates
- Window functions (RANK, ROW_NUMBER, LAG)
- NULL behavior (#1 gotcha)
- Top-N per group

🗣️ HOW TO ANSWER IN INTERVIEWS

- Restate the question in your words
- Ask about NULLs, ties, edge cases
- Talk through approach before coding
- Mention alternatives (CTE vs subquery)
- Discuss performance + indexes

✂️ PRACTICE ROUTINE

- 2-3 problems per day, not 10
- 30 min max per problem — then peek
- Type queries by hand, no copy-paste
- Re-solve hard ones 1 week later
- Write a one-line comment explaining the trick

⚠️ MISTAKES THAT FAIL INTERVIEWS

- Jumping to code without clarifying
- Using = NULL not IS NULL
- WHERE with aggregates (use HAVING)
- Confusing RANK / ROW_NUMBER / DENSE_RANK
- Silence — talk through your thinking

📌 Top 10 to bookmark right now

- ▶ leetcode.com/problemset/database/ — The interview standard
- ▶ datalemur.com — FAANG data science questions, free tier
- ▶ stratascratch.com — Most companies covered
- ▶ sqlzoo.net — Beginner-friendly interactive
- ▶ mode.com/sql-tutorial/ — Best free SQL course
- ▶ 8weeksqlchallenge.com — Real-world case studies
- ▶ pgexercises.com — Postgres-specific drill
- ▶ pramp.com — Free mock interviews
- ▶ kaggle.com/learn/intro-to-sql — BigQuery + big data
- ▶ github.com/Mani5266/sql — SQLSENSEI (you're here 📌)

Go practice.

You don't need 15 platforms. You need 3, and consistency.
Open LeetCode. Pick an Easy. Solve it. Tomorrow, pick another.
4 weeks of that and you'll surprise yourself.

github.com/Mani5266/sql

SQLSENSEI • Patient. Precise. Practical.